

Velázquez

One of the most influential painters in history and the pre-eminent artist of the Spanish Golden Age, Velázquez (1599–1660) had a realist approach with an added element of emotion in his portraits, and religious, mythological and historical subjects. He began his career producing *bodegóns* that show Caravaggio's influence, and his later work reveals great mastery of capturing light, atmosphere and colour, using unprecedented loose and fluid brushmarks, natural style and ease of manner.

At 24, he became court painter to Philip IV (1605–65) – the only artist allowed to paint the king. At court, he studied paintings in the royal collection and befriended Peter Paul Rubens when he was in Madrid in 1628. He also visited Italy to study the art and buy paintings for the king. Becoming close friends with the king and his family, he continued to rise up the ranks of the royal household. His last years were mostly taken up with royal portraits, and in 1658 he was made a Knight of Santiago, an honour he had always desired.



Velázquez, *Las Meninas*, 1656